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RESEARCH ARTICLE

More is less? The volunteer stewardship framework and models[†]

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Scholars have devoted substantial attention to developing conditional models of volunteer administration and management, but no consensus surrounds the criteria underlying the different models or the rationale. The literature reveals a welter of possibilities but no clear choice. This study conceives the primary managerial challenges as securing access to and guiding volunteer energy into productive volunteering, and the volunteer administrator as the central actor in this process. Based on how volunteers are accessed and guided in their roles, we develop the Volunteer Stewardship Framework, which distinguishes volunteer administration according to two key dimensions: organizational access to volunteer energy (private resource vs. common pool) and guidance of volunteers (unitary vs. shared). Results of a survey of volunteer administration practitioners in the Netherlands show that respondents working under the four models emanating from the Framework recognize different elements of volunteer administration as “Very Important.”

KEYWORDS

corporate volunteering, volunteers, volunteer center, volunteer management, third-party model

1 | INTRODUCTION

The study of the management of volunteer programs dates to the late 1960s and early 1970s and was popularized in the 1990s (Brudney, Lee, Afif, Ockenden, & Sillah, 2016)—and in some ways it remains grounded in that era. In a comprehensive review of the literature on volunteer coordination,

[†]The authors dedicate this article to the memory of our friend, teacher, and mentor, Susan J. Ellis. May Susan's memory be for a blessing.

Studer and von Schnurbein (2013) find that contemporary treatments of volunteer administration and management still tend to adopt a Human Resource Management (HRM) approach pioneered during that era. Likewise, Safrit and Schmiesing (2012) review nine models of volunteer administration and find they are similar in integrating principal elements of HRM, including those identified by Studer and von Schnurbein (2013) related to planning, recruitment, performance assurance, retention, and separation (Walk, Zhang, & Littlepage, in press). The dominance of the HRM approach is disconcerting, given “that the transfer of HRM practices and theory onto the volunteer coordination situation is only half of the picture” (Studer & von Schnurbein, 2013, p. 423). Other scholars have recognized the need noted by Seel and Rehnborg (2016, pp. 4–6) to shift models of volunteer management from hierarchy to engagement.

In this article we present a more expansive and, we think, up-to-date view of the volunteer management task in a new Volunteer Stewardship Framework. We use the term “stewardship” to recognize the need to move from an instrumental volunteer management HRM approach to an emphasis on volunteer engagement. The Framework joins two crucial dimensions, access to volunteer energy and guidance of volunteers, meant to capture the diversity and complexity of the situations in which volunteer managers work. We propose that the four models of volunteer management emanating from the Framework call for different practices on the part of these officials; we test this proposition empirically based on a sample of 362 practitioners involved in volunteer administration in the Netherlands. The findings demonstrate that the volunteer management practices that this group regards as “Very Important” vary in comprehensible ways based on our Framework formulation, and provide evidence that “best practices” in volunteer administration extend beyond HRM.

2 | BACKGROUND

The literature offers a substantial number of volunteer management models (Hager & Brudney, 2015). Because comprehensive reviews of the models are available (Brudney & Meijs, 2014; Safrit & Schmiesing, 2012), we do not replicate them here. Brudney and Meijs (2014) show that the models can be categorized into two groups: a traditional or general model adapted from the paid workplace, and a much larger family of contingency or conditional models intended for particular situations or circumstances confronting volunteer administrators.

Despite persistence of the traditional model, scholarship has moved toward endorsement of contingency approaches. Paull (2002) writes, “a ‘one size fits all’ approach is inappropriate for volunteer management ... ‘it really does depend on the type of organization’” (p. 25). Meijs and Ten Hoorn (2008, p. 29) concur, “There is simply no best way of organizing volunteers, neither in volunteer run organizations, in government organizations, in nonprofit organizations with mostly paid staff, nor in businesses. Volunteering, volunteers and the way they are organized and managed differs from context to context.” Rochester (1999) concludes, “One size does not fit all.” Brudney and Sink (2017) show that the traditional workplace model can (should) be adapted according to organizational circumstances, such as size, client groups served, demographics of volunteers, and so on, and agree that “Volunteer management: It all depends.”

Notwithstanding the potential utility that might be afforded by having numerous conditional models for volunteer management each predicated on a particular situation, the number of models from which to choose can prove more intimidating than enlightening. Moreover, the different models tend to be grounded on ephemeral and changing conditions and circumstances of the host organization and/or its volunteer program. These conditions/circumstances can prove difficult to detect, let alone measure, including volunteer motivations, duration of volunteer service, organizational

mission, organizational culture, and so on. We introduce the Volunteer Stewardship Framework to surmount these issues, and to yield greater understanding of the work settings and demands that confront modern volunteer administration.

3 | THE VOLUNTEER STEWARDSHIP FRAMEWORK

As Hustinx and colleagues (Hustinx, Cnaan, & Handy, 2010; Hustinx, Handy, & Cnaan, 2010) argue, volunteering is a complex, multidimensional concept that requires an understanding of the context in which it occurs, a conclusion shared more recently by Nesbit, Christensen, and Brudney (2018). In their review of the volunteer management models that describe this context, Brudney and Meijs (2014) observe that contingency or conditional management models are based on the characteristics of either the volunteer or the program or organization that supports this activity. Volunteer-focused criteria relate to such factors as the motivations of volunteers, their willingness to commit time, and their connection to the organization. Program/organization criteria center on other factors pertaining, for example, to the structure, type, and mission of the organization.

The Volunteer Stewardship Framework introduced in this article joins these two dimensions. With regard to the first, the Framework builds on Rehnborg's (2009, p. 9) criterion of volunteers' connection to service. At one end of this continuum lies the "affiliation-oriented" volunteer, who "gravitates to a service-opportunity in order to associate him or her self—with either the cause or with the mission or purpose of the organization, or with the group or network of friends engaged in the service. For this volunteer, the orientation to the type of service, or the friends or colleagues with whom they will serve, is of greater significance than the type of work being done. By contrast, the 'skill-oriented' volunteer ... is a person who is more likely to express an interest in or a connection with the type of work performed as a volunteer. This person views the skills that he or she brings to service as paramount and wants to offer this specialized expertise to the organization."

From the perspective of the volunteer administrator (rather than the volunteer), the Volunteer Stewardship Framework conceives of the connection dimension as relating to how the organization obtains access to the "volunteer energy" necessary to undertake its work (Brudney & Meijs, 2009). This continuum ranges from whether the volunteer administrator enjoys private access to the needed volunteer energy versus shares common access with other organizations that use volunteers.

Following Brudney and Meijs (2009), we conceive of volunteer energy as a natural resource to which volunteer-involving organizations need access. Extending their natural resources metaphor, we can differentiate between *private* and *common* access to volunteer energy. Private access refers to cases in which the volunteer-involving organization has knowledge of or access to a limited group of potential volunteers who are affiliated or associated with it; examples include members who volunteer for a professional association, employees in corporate volunteer programs, and students who engage in projects or other learning activities outside of but organized by their school. In Rehnborg's (2009) framework these volunteers have an orientation or affiliation with the goals of the organization or with friends, associates, or colleagues in the organization with whom they will volunteer. According to Meijs and Hoogstad (2001), this condition calls for the membership management model to work effectively with volunteers (c.f., Rochester, 1999).

At the other end of the access continuum in the Volunteer Stewardship Framework lies common access to volunteer energy, which refers to recruitment from the pool of volunteers in the larger community. These volunteers are unknown to or not previously associated with the host organization; examples include volunteers to a homeless shelter or to other nonprofit (or government) service-delivery organizations, or people seeking the assistance of a volunteer center to find a suitable

opportunity. Although the cause or mission of the organization likely plays a role in activating these volunteers to service, we share Rehnborg's (2009) view that these volunteers are generally more "skill-oriented" and endeavor to forward organizational goals through their volunteering, rather than being drawn or available to serve through affiliation or membership ties. Accordingly, host organizations will need to compete to recruit these volunteers and will strive to place them in positions where they can be most effectual. Meijs and Hoogstad (2001) describe such access and deployment of volunteer energy as the "program management model," while Rochester (1999) uses the terms "service delivery model" or "support role model" depending primarily on the balance of work performed by paid staff versus volunteers.

The second criterion underlying contingency or conditional models of volunteer management is characteristics of the program or organization that supports the volunteering, such as its structure, type, or mission (Brudney & Meijs, 2014). In the Volunteer Stewardship Framework this second dimension incorporates the manner in which the organization provides guidance for volunteers, distinguishing whether a single focal organization provides *unitary* management or guidance for the volunteer, or the focal organization and a partner have *shared* responsibility for this task.

Although the first dimension in the Volunteer Stewardship Framework, access to volunteer energy, has roots dating back some 20 years (see Meijs & Hoogstad, 2001; Rochester, 1999), the second dimension, guidance of the volunteer, is a more recent development—and need—meant to capture emerging trends in volunteering and volunteer management. Haski-Leventhal et al. (2010, p. 143) explain, "Against the background of a generally accepted idea that volunteering must be encouraged, and the emergence of new forms of volunteering, such as corporate volunteering or service learning, it becomes clear that not only are the volunteer organisations and individuals responsible for such encouragement, but third parties can also play an important role. Governments, corporations and educational institutes may all enhance the volunteerability of individuals and the recruitability of volunteer organisations." As opposed to the service and membership management models featuring unitary control by a focal organization over the volunteer program, businesses through corporate volunteering and schools through community service and service learning are engaged in supporting and promoting volunteering through their work with other organizations that share in the guidance of the volunteer. This trend toward "third-party volunteering" or shared guidance of volunteers has been accelerated by other changes in the "landscape of volunteering ... as a result of recent institutional and organisational efforts to promote volunteerism, and accommodate (perceived) changes in the personal preferences and social conditions of volunteers. There has been a mushrooming of more episodic and project-based volunteering opportunities, which often are joint initiatives with external parties (governments, corporations, schools), such as national service days, volunteering through employee-based volunteer programmes, service learning in education, and volunteering to government in stipended volunteer programmes" (Hustinx & Meijs, 2011).

At one end of the guidance dimension in the Volunteer Stewardship Framework stand volunteer programs in which guidance of the volunteer is unitary or provided by one organization, and at the other third-party arrangements in which the focal organization and a partner organization have shared guidance. Although this second dimension of the Framework is emergent, we can adapt terms introduced by Salamon and Anheier (1996) to describe it. These authors (pp. 5–6) refer to the "home organization" as the institutional origin or starting place from which volunteer energy is accessed and volunteers are drawn or recruited, and the "host organization" denotes the agency, or the institutional auspices, where volunteers are placed and perform their work. Thus, guidance for the volunteer can emanate from a unitary volunteer program in which the home organization from which the volunteer energy is accessed is the same or very close to the host organization in which the volunteers are

placed and perform their work. For example, in the membership organizations discussed by Tschirhart (2006) and Tschirhart and Gazley (2014) members belong to the home organization, and this same organization is the site or host of their volunteer activities (for instance, association members volunteer to promote the association). The home and host organizations can be closely related but not necessarily identical: Nonprofit and government service-delivery organizations recruit volunteers from the community (home) and place and guide them internally (host) to serve the needs of their clients, for example, for counseling, mentoring, and other assistance.

Alternatively, in other volunteer programs the home and the host organizations are more distinct, so that volunteer guidance is shared. In corporate or employee volunteer programs, the corporation is the home or source of the volunteer energy, and other organizations or projects in the community serve as the hosts where the energy is mobilized. In educational institutions, schools constitute the home to the volunteer energy, while host sites in the community are the recipients. As another example, volunteer centers deploy volunteer energy to organizational hosts in the community (van den Bos, 2014; Osborne, 1999). In the shared volunteer program models both the home and the host organizations have responsibility for guidance of volunteers. These shared guidance arrangements for volunteers are analogous to the “matrix organization” in business in which employees have both a hierarchical superior responsible for overall guidance and oversight, and a functional or project supervisor who provides more specific guidance and direction on a project—with the associated challenges (Burton, Obel, & Hakonsson, 2015). Although the traditional HRM-based volunteer management models may be useful especially for unitary volunteer programs, they overlook the demands and tensions created when distinct home and host organizations share volunteer guidance.

The Volunteer Stewardship Framework focuses on these two crucial aspects of volunteer management: securing access to potential volunteers, and guiding these volunteers in activities that create value for the major parties involved, such as the volunteer, the home organization, the host organization, and the client. For the task of accessing volunteer energy, the volunteer manager may have a focus on a predefined set of volunteers known, or at least familiar, to her or him, such as members of the organization, employees of the company or students at the university (private access), or on an undefined broader arena called the volunteer commons, consisting of volunteers unknown or unfamiliar to the volunteer administrator (common access). Private access in this respect means that the volunteer-involving organization has knowledge about, or association with a private, and limited group of potential volunteers, such as members in membership organizations, employees in corporate volunteer programs and students in service learning. Common access means that the potential volunteers are community-based and rather anonymous with respect to the recruiting organization. Likewise, for the task of guidance of the volunteers, managers may be able to control the entire process (unitary), or may need to share the responsibility with other volunteer managers in host organizations outside the

TABLE 1 Volunteer stewardship framework

	Access to volunteer energy	
	Private resource	Common pool
Guidance of volunteers	Unitary	Membership model Service model
		Examples: Membership association, self-help group
		Examples: Volunteer service-delivery program in a nonprofit organization or government agency
	Shared	Secondary model Intermediary model
		Examples: Corporate volunteer program, school-based volunteer program
		Examples: Volunteer center, “voluntourism” agency

home organization (shared). Cross-classifying these essential volunteer management tasks of access and guidance, we can identify four types of volunteer management models, as shown in Table 1.

Two models in the Volunteer Stewardship Framework feature unitary guidance of volunteers. We denote organizations that have private access to volunteer energy and unitary guidance of their volunteers as *membership*; members of a soccer association belong to the organization and volunteer to meet its objectives. By contrast, *service* organizations enjoy common access to volunteers from across the community and recruit and mobilize the resulting volunteer energy to meet their own goals to assist clients (unitary guidance), as exemplified by a homeless shelter, food pantry, or many government-based volunteer programs.

The Volunteer Stewardship Framework likewise distinguishes two models of shared volunteer programs. The first consists of *secondary* programs in which the participants emanate from a clearly defined home organization (private access) and volunteer outside of it for other organizational hosts that oversee their service (shared guidance). Prominent examples include schools that encourage (or require) volunteer service by their students in the community and/or service learning; other examples are corporations that foster and perform projects using their employees that assist other host (volunteer-involving) organizations in the community and help to meet the community social responsibility goals of the home organization (corporate volunteering). Haski-Leventhal, Meijs, and Hustinx (2010) refer to these examples as “third-party involvement.”

We call the second model of shared volunteer programs *intermediary*. These programs consist of volunteer centers or bureaus (and like organizations) that connect volunteers from across the community or from various home organizations (common access) with opportunities for their service in host organizations eager to make use of their (donated) labor (shared guidance). A volunteer center plays this connecting role by placing volunteers in various host organizations outside of it, or by working with another home organization (e.g., a religious institution, social club, civic organization) to place volunteers from these entities in host organizations. Other examples represent the “hyphen” approach to volunteer involvement, which is based on combining volunteering with another activity in the busy schedules/agendas of prospective volunteers to provoke them to donate time, such as singles-volunteering and done-in-a-day volunteering. Both shared models are examples of the volunteer “re-embedding” rationales and instruments described by Hustinx and Meijs (2011).

The development of the Volunteer Stewardship Framework builds on three inter-related research streams in which (some of) the authors have been involved sometimes with other researchers over an extended period. The oldest stream focuses on the content of volunteer management in service versus mutual support organizations showing that effective practices differ according to organizational contexts (Meijs & Hoogstad, 2001). The next stream is rooted in the concept of volunteer energy and is concerned with how this potentiality can be maintained and mobilized at the societal level (Brudney & Meijs, 2009; 2013; Meijs, Ten Hoorn, & Brudney, 2006). The most recent research stream follows up by investigating the role of new third parties, new stakeholders, and new forms of volunteering in activating volunteer energy (Haski-Leventhal, Meijs, & Hustinx, 2010). The Volunteer Stewardship Framework proposes that the activation process will take different forms and be advantaged by different management practices according to the four models we have identified.

4 | VOLUNTEER MANAGEMENT MODELS AND PRACTICES

If the differences incorporated in the models of volunteer management emanating from the Volunteer Stewardship Framework have merit, we might expect to see them reflected in the management practices exhibited by practitioners in each model. When the guidance of the volunteers is unitary as in member and service models, the focus of the traditional volunteer management literature on the

internal and HRM elements is understandable and appropriate (Safrit & Schmiesing, 2012; Studer & von Schnurbein, 2013). Yet, the expected difference in volunteer management practices necessitated by the shared program models compared to their unitary counterparts is more profound, rooted in the need to work inter-organizationally between home and host organizations, raising challenges parallel to matrix organizations in the business management literature (Burton, Obel, & Hakonsson, 2015).

Administrators of volunteers in shared programs should be attuned not only to the management issues of working with volunteers in their home organization but also to collaboration and partnership with host organizations that manage the volunteers on site (or virtually, if the volunteering occurs electronically). In addition to the traditional internal HRM practices such as attending to volunteer recruitment, job descriptions, recognition, evaluation, and so on, they must engage in externally oriented volunteer management practices with host organizations, including communicating with organizations where they place volunteers, searching for organizations to place volunteers, raising interest in volunteering in the community, reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to the home organization, and organizing, staffing, or promoting volunteering in the community. In this research we evaluate empirically whether and how volunteer management practices differ between the more traditional unitary volunteer program models—member and service—and the upcoming shared programs—secondary and intermediary.

We could find no treatment of volunteer management in the secondary and intermediary models in leading handbooks or review articles (e.g., Brudney, 2016; Safrit & Schmiesing, 2012; Seel & Rehnborg, 2016), and only scant treatment in others (“Volunteers from the Workplace” in McCurley & Lynch, 2011, pp. 170–173; “Employer-supported volunteering” in Rochester, Paine, Howlett, & Zimmeck, 2012, pp. 107–110). Limited literature applies a volunteer management perspective to corporate volunteering (e.g., Benjamin, 2001; Roza, Shachar, Meijs, & Hustinx, 2017; Samuel, Wolf, & Schilling, 2013; Tschirhart, 2005) or to other manifestations of the secondary model such as service learning and court-referred volunteering (Haski-Leventhal, Meijs, & Hustinx, 2010). The same can be said with respect to the intermediary model, although van den Bos (2014) and Osborne (1999) describe volunteer centers more generally. We identified only one article that deals directly with the challenge of managing volunteers in shared programs: Follman, Cseh, and Brudney (2016) examine management of public-nonprofit volunteer program partnerships in U.S. national parks.

With but few exceptions, then, the volunteer management aspects of the shared volunteer guidance model have not received serious treatment. Even in voluntourism, where activities of volunteering and tourism are combined and, in most cases, organized according to the intermediary model, the major research question is typically whether host communities are helped, and how assistance to them might be improved. Solutions include better preparation in the home country (Seymour, Benzian, & Kalenderian, 2013) or in greater guidance of on-site volunteering. Although these aspects present issues for volunteer management, limited research combines both volunteer managers into the same process (see Kumaran & Pappas, 2011).

We examine and compare empirically below the four models emanating from the Volunteer Stewardship Framework: member, service, secondary, and intermediary. Our guiding proposition is that practitioners working with volunteers under these four conditions will find different aspects of volunteer management to be more (or less) important according to their particular model. We might anticipate largest differences between practitioners in the unitary guidance models (member and service) versus their counterparts in the shared guidance models (secondary and intermediary): The latter models must be concerned not only with establishing the internal management HRM features of volunteer administration but also with promoting external relations and coordination with various host organizations, as well as raising awareness and receptivity of volunteerism in the larger community where volunteers are placed.

5 | RESEARCH METHODS

To evaluate our proposed Volunteer Stewardship Framework empirically the authors conducted an on-line survey of practitioners who work with volunteers in the Netherlands. The survey was developed at the Rotterdam School of Management (Erasmus University), and posted on social media sites. The Nederlandse Organisaties Vrijwilligerswerk (Netherlands Organizations on Volunteering), a networking and interest organization for volunteer work in the Netherlands, shared the survey with its broad network of volunteer organizations as well. The survey was open for 6 weeks in late 2017 and yielded a sample of approximately 450 practitioners encompassing the diversity of Dutch volunteer practitioners. All respondents work with volunteers, and most are volunteer/project coordinators (53.6%). Nearly all work for a nonprofit organization (95.6%).

5.1 | Survey protocol

The survey protocol presented items to determine the type of organization/model in relation to volunteer involvement in which respondents worked, and whether they held a paid or unpaid position. Of the total sample we could classify 362 respondents unambiguously as working in the membership, service, secondary, or intermediary models of volunteer involvement. We checked on nonlogical combinations of job titles and organizational profiles and excluded political (15) and religious (28) organizations.¹ Our empirical analysis focuses on the question, “In your work with volunteers, is each of the following elements very important, somewhat important, or not important at all?” The elements encompass 16 volunteer management practices enumerated in Tables 3 and 4.

Given the emphasis on unitary guidance of volunteers and HRM found in the literature, we were able to draw on existing items assessing “best” volunteer management practices in research by Hager and Brudney (2004).² For the shared guidance volunteer programs we introduce and elaborate in this article, however, we had to create new items for empirical evaluation based on the needs of these entities. We included four items with a specific focus on the shared (secondary and intermediary) models: “Communicating with organizations where you place volunteers,” “Searching for organizations to place volunteers,” “Raising interest in volunteering in the community,” and “Organizing, staffing, or promoting volunteering events in your community, such as days of service.” A fifth item was intended to tap the complications of volunteer coordination that could ensue in large secondary and intermediary organizations when several volunteer administrators may be involved in overseeing participants in the field: “Coordinating with other volunteer managers in your organization.” The responses to these items allow test of the central proposition of this study that the important elements or tasks of volunteer administration vary according to the different models in which practitioners find themselves.

We were also interested in testing whether reactions by Studer and von Schnurbein (2013), Seel and Rehnborg (2016), and others to the dominance of the HRM approach had been taken up in practice to acknowledge and integrate more fully the needs and importance of the volunteer to the organization. Brudney and Meijjs (2009) proposed a “regenerative” approach meant to move volunteer management away from an “instrumental” use of volunteers by organizations toward the mutual interests and accomplishments of both parties, from short-term to long-term volunteer engagement, from volunteer “job descriptions” to an appreciation of volunteer assets, from the “fit” of the volunteer to the organization to the “negotiation” between them. In our empirical analysis we experiment with three proposed elements of volunteer management meant to tap this perspective: “Reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to your organization,” “Discussing future plans with volunteers, including further involvement or ending involvement,” and “Evaluating and rewarding volunteers.”

TABLE 2 Respondents working in each type of volunteer management model

Model	Respondents	Percentage of respondents	Paid respondents	Percentage of paid respondents
Membership	123	37.0	78	63.4
Service	160	44.2	124	77.5
Secondary	40	11.0	35	87.5
Intermediary	39	10.8	31	79.5
Total	362	100.0	268	74.0

5.2 | Survey respondents

Table 2 presents the distribution of respondents across the four models of volunteer administration and management that we have identified and the percentage of paid versus unpaid respondents. According to the Netherlands Central Bureau of Statistics (Arends & Smeets, 2018), nearly half (49.1%) of the Dutch population over age 15 volunteered in the past year (2017). Most volunteered for sports clubs (14.5%), followed by schools (11.3%), (home) care and nursing (8.6%), youth organizations (8.5%), churches and philosophical organizations (7.4%), cultural associations (5.0%), organizations serving the district/neighborhood (4.7%), or hobby and social clubs (4.5%). Fewer volunteered for trade unions and organizations supporting living conditions, political parties, victim aid or social assistance. Thus, a high percentage of Dutch volunteers are active in membership associations (sport clubs, youth organizations, cultural associations, hobby and social clubs, etc.) or in organizations that know their “members” well such as (primary) schools.

Consequently, a substantial number of volunteer-involving organizations in the Netherlands are membership-based, and most of them, certainly the sport-, youth-, and cultural- associations, are grassroots associations, that is, “locally based, basically autonomous, volunteer-run, formal, nonprofit groups that have an official membership of volunteers” (Smith, 1997, p. 2). Because the majority of volunteer-involving organizations in the Netherlands are sports association/grassroots,³ we can understand why in our survey so many respondents fall into the Membership Organization category (34.0%), and accordingly why a relatively large proportion of the volunteer administrators’ sample is unpaid (26%). As one might expect, though, most respondents work in service-delivery organizations that involve volunteers (44.2%).

Meijs and Hoogstad (2001) claim that concepts such as Corporate Volunteering and Community Service were largely unknown in the Netherlands at the time of their research, and that bringing in external volunteers was not needed, and certainly not common, among most volunteer involving organizations. Such programs have only started emerging in the Netherlands over the last twenty years (see Van der Voort, Glac, & Meijs, 2009 for a case study of an early innovator in Dutch Corporate Volunteering that had only begun in 1997). As a result, much lower numbers of respondents work in the jointly shared management models, secondary and intermediary, and are, thus, found in our sample of volunteer administrators (11.0% and 10.8%, respectively). Also, because volunteer centers, which constitute an important part of the intermediary model, almost always work with Dutch municipalities to integrate, promote, and manage volunteer opportunities available in other organizations, they are relatively few in number; the Netherlands has (only) 241 volunteer centers (Ploegmakers, Merkus, & Terpstra, 2011), substantially fewer than membership organizations and service-delivery organizations, which number in the thousands (see Note 3).

6 | FINDINGS

Table 3 examines the perceptions of the respondents concerning the importance of the central elements of volunteer administration proposed in this study. The table displays the percentages of

TABLE 3 Volunteer management practices viewed as Very Important by type of volunteer management model

Element	Type of volunteer management model				F (p)	Sample (n = 362)
	Membership (n = 123)	Service (n = 160)	Secondary (n = 40)	Intermediary (n = 39)		
Regular supervision and communication with volunteers	75.6	81.9	87.5	89.7	1.823 (p < 0.141)	81.2
Liability coverage or insurance protection for volunteers	59.3	57.5	55.0	46.2	0.732 (p < 0.534)	56.6
Screening procedures to identify suitable volunteers	48.0	50.6	47.5	48.7	0.084 (p < 0.969)	49.2
Recognition activities, such as award ceremonies for volunteers	39.0	50.6	57.5	43.6	1.987 (p < 0.116)	46.7
Written policies and job descriptions for volunteer involvement	41.5	42.5	50.0	38.5	0.408 (p < 0.747)	42.5
Training for paid staff in working with volunteers	24.4	43.8	37.5	41.0	4.021 (p < 0.008)	36.2
Annual measurement of the impacts of volunteers	22.8	30.0	32.5	30.8	0.845 (p < 0.470)	27.9
Regular collection of information on volunteer numbers and hours	21.1	20.6	32.5	23.1	0.918 (p < 0.432)	22.4
<i>Raising interest in volunteering in the community</i>	48.0	50.6	57.5	82.1	5.187 (p < 0.002)	53.9
<i>Coordinating with other volunteer managers in your organization</i>	48.8	46.3	52.5	51.3	0.232 (p < 0.874)	48.3
<i>Communicating with organizations where you place volunteers</i>	19.5	38.1	42.5	74.4	14.978 (p < 0.001)	36.2
<i>Organizing, staffing, or promoting volunteering events in your community, such as days of service</i>	28.5	31.3	45.0	66.7	7.725 (p < 0.001)	35.6
<i>Searching for organizations to place volunteers</i>	3.3	12.5	20.0	56.4	27.422 (p < 0.001)	14.9
Evaluating and rewarding volunteers	62.5	74.4	75.0	69.2	1.718 (p < 0.163)	69.9
Discussing future plans with volunteers, including further involvement or ending involvement	58.5	53.1	67.5	61.5	1.065 (p < 0.364)	57.5
Reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to your organization	31.7	45.0	47.5	33.3	2.299 (p < 0.077)	39.5

Notes. Table reports percentages. Bold indicates statistically significant difference. Italics indicates elements for shared guidance models.

respondents who rated as “Very Important” a listing of volunteer management elements; the table shows the percentages for the entire sample, and for the four groups of respondents classified according to the type of organization or model in which they work: Membership, Service delivery, Secondary, and Intermediary. For each element we performed analysis of variance (ANOVA) to determine whether the differences in the percentages across the models were sufficiently robust to warrant rejection of the null hypothesis of no difference.⁴ Tables 3 and 4 include the same listing of volunteer administration elements; for convenience we place horizontal lines in these tables to distinguish the HRM elements used by Hager and Brudney (2004), the new items meant to capture an external, shared guidance approach to volunteer administration, and the new items pertaining to “regenerative” volunteer management (Brudney & Meijs, 2009).

Table 3 supports several main findings. First, as we had anticipated, across the four models significant differences in attributions of “Very Important” occur with respect to the items assessing the demands of the shared guidance models (secondary and intermediary) versus the unitary guidance models (membership and service models): “Communicating with organizations where you place volunteers” ($p < 0.001$), “Searching for organizations to place volunteers” ($p < 0.001$), “Raising interest in volunteering in the community” ($p < 0.002$), and “Organizing, staffing, or promoting volunteering events in your community, such as days of service” ($p < 0.001$). The element “Coordinating with other volunteer managers in your organization,” proposed to distinguish the two sets of models, particularly in larger organizations, did not yield statistically significant differences. For each of the other items, respondents working in the secondary and intermediary models more often viewed the elements as Very Important, and usually by large differences in percentages, especially in the intermediary model. This finding suggests the distinctiveness of the volunteer guidance or management task when multiple home and host organizations are involved, as in the secondary and intermediary models.

Second, this distinctiveness notwithstanding, the results in Table 3 show remarkable similarity in the respondents' attributions of Very Important across the HRM elements of volunteer administration. Regardless of the model in which the respondents labor, approximately the same percentages viewed the items proposed and tested by Hager and Brudney (2004) as Very Important, so that statistically significant differences do not occur. Nearly half of the respondents consider Very Important classic items including “Regular supervision and communication with volunteers” (81.2%), “Liability coverage or insurance protection for volunteers” (56.6%), “Screening procedures to identify suitable volunteers” (49.2%), “Recognition activities, such as award ceremonies for volunteers” (46.7%), and “Written policies and job descriptions for volunteer involvement” (42.5%). Likewise, across the models the items tapping measurement do not produce statistically significant differences either, although they are deemed Very Important much less often by respondents (“Regular collection of information on volunteer numbers and hours,” 22.4%; “Annual measurement of the impacts of volunteers,” 27.9%). Thus, the HRM elements of volunteer administration do seem to apply across the board. The implication for those working in the shared guidance models is that the demands of the job overflow beyond HRM to encompass the coordination and external relations elements as well.

We had anticipated that the items tapping any movement of volunteer administration away from an instrumental human resource management perspective might be evidenced in larger percentages of Very Important ratings in the unitary guidance models, where volunteer managers might have more continuous contact with and concern for enhancing the volunteer experience of participants. The results in Table 3 do not support this contention, however. None of the analyses of variance for the three items we created and tested for this purpose, “Discussing future plans with volunteers, including further involvement or ending involvement” (57.5%), “Evaluating and rewarding volunteers” (69.9%), and “Reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to your organization” (39.5%), yield statistically significant differences. To the degree that these items tap a more volunteer-centered perspective, the uptake seems to be universal, rather than varied across the models.

In the ANOVA the percentage differences across the models for the last of these items, “Reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to your organization,” approaches statistical significance ($p < 0.077$). Although the pattern of percentage differences is not what we might have expected, it is readily comprehensible. Given business concerns with Corporate Social Responsibility and Corporate Community Involvement, volunteer administrators in the secondary model (47.5%) apparently face greatest need to demonstrate and report results with volunteers, and those in the service-delivery model (45.0%) have long struggled to convince organizational leadership of the

importance and impact of volunteers (Connors, 2011). By contrast, such concerns are greatly moderated in membership organizations (31.7%), where the importance of contributing toward organizational goals is implicitly understood and needs scant, if any, reminder, and in the intermediary model (33.3%), which lacks a natural constituency to report results.

Extended across the other elements, this more fine-grained analysis suggests the distinctiveness of the membership model. Not only on this element but also on nine others in Table 3, the volunteer administrators in the membership model give the lowest percentage of “Very Important” ratings; on five other items their percentage is the second lowest. Across all elements in the table the percentage of “Very Important” ratings is greatest just once in regard to “liability coverage or insurance protection for volunteers.” This relatively high percentage (59.3%) might be explained by the fact that many Dutch municipalities have a policy for free insurance and liability coverage for volunteers in small local volunteer-involving organizations. In general, practitioners in the membership model less often consider the elements of volunteer administration enumerated in Table 3 “Very Important,” and training for paid staff in working with volunteers reaches its nadir in this model: Only about one-quarter (24.4%) consider it “Very Important”—compared to an average of 40.8% in the other three models—which can partly be explained because more organizations in the membership model have no paid staff. Interestingly though, the Dutch National Olympic Committee*National Sport Federation reports that sports associations are moving to a more “consumerist model” in which a growing number of these membership organizations hire more paid staff (van der Roest, 2016). Further research is needed to explain why membership organizations score consistently lower on these elements, including the question of whether additional elements are needed.

To this point the analysis demonstrates four conclusions. First, according to the attributions of the volunteer managers responding to the survey, the elements of volunteer management seem to have extended in the shared guidance models, secondary and intermediary. Here the need to work externally with other organizations in volunteer guidance seems to be confirmed by statistically significant differences in the items assessing this dimension. Second, notwithstanding, the human resource management elements seem to have sustained across all models, with the exception of measurement aspects, which command much lower evaluation of “Very Important.” Third, two of the items meant to capture a more volunteer-centered approach different from HRM receive some support as “Very Important” elements of volunteer administration across the models, with an apparent high take-up rate of well over 50%; many fewer of the respondents consider the third element “Very Important” (“Reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to your organization,” 39.5%). Fourth, volunteer administration practitioners in the membership model give the lowest attributions of “Very Important” to this new understanding of the elements of volunteer management.

If these findings suggest an emerging tool kit or technology of volunteer administration, we would expect to find greater substantiation of this result among the more professional volunteer practitioners. Although the measurement of professionalism can be contested, especially in the field of volunteer administration where scholars strive to evaluate the status of the field (Brudney & Storti, 2016), one indicator is receiving material compensation, that is, being paid. In fact, a rationale for organizations choosing to compensate volunteer practitioners is recognition of the learning and skills they possess to comprehend and implement a set of recommended “best” practices. To the degree that the new technology of volunteer administration suggested by our analysis has taken hold, we would expect paid respondents, our indicator of professionalism, to consider the elements of volunteer management as “Very Important” more often than their unpaid counterparts. Table 4 explores this hypothesis.

The analyses of variance reported in the table provide strong support for this hypothesis. For each of the 16 items in our inventory of managerial elements, higher percentages of paid versus unpaid

TABLE 4 Volunteer management practices viewed as Very Important by paid versus unpaid volunteer managers

Element	Paid versus unpaid volunteer managers		T (p)	Sample (n = 362)
	Paid (n = 268)	Unpaid (n = 94)		
Regular supervision and communication with volunteers	84.0	73.4	2.068 (p < 0.041)	81.2
Liability coverage or insurance protection for volunteers	58.6	51.1	1.265 (p < 0.207)	56.6
Screening procedures to identify suitable volunteers	51.9	41.5	1.743 (p < 0.083)	49.2
Recognition activities, such as award ceremonies for volunteers	51.9	31.9	3.488 (p < 0.001)	46.7
Written policies and job descriptions for volunteer involvement	47.8	27.7	3.619 (p < 0.001)	42.5
Training for paid staff in working with volunteers	42.5	18.1	4.882 (p < 0.001)	36.2
Annual measurement of the impacts of volunteers	31.0	19.1	2.381 (p < 0.018)	27.9
Regular collection of information on volunteer numbers and hours	25.4	13.8	2.587 (p < 0.010)	22.4
<i>Raising interest in volunteering in the community</i>	<i>58.2</i>	<i>41.5</i>	<i>2.821 (p < 0.005)</i>	<i>53.9</i>
<i>Coordinating with other volunteer managers in your organization</i>	<i>52.2</i>	<i>37.2</i>	<i>2.556 (p < 0.011)</i>	<i>48.3</i>
<i>Communicating with organizations where you place volunteers</i>	<i>41.8</i>	<i>20.2</i>	<i>4.196 (p < 0.001)</i>	<i>36.2</i>
<i>Organizing, staffing, or promoting volunteering events in your community, such as days of service</i>	<i>37.7</i>	<i>29.8</i>	<i>1.412 (p < 0.160)</i>	<i>35.6</i>
<i>Searching for organizations to place volunteers</i>	<i>18.3</i>	<i>5.3</i>	<i>3.907 (p < 0.001)</i>	<i>14.9</i>
Evaluating and rewarding volunteers	71.6	64.9	1.191 (p < 0.235)	69.9
Discussing future plans with volunteers, including further involvement or ending involvement	58.2	55.3	0.484 (p < 0.629)	57.5
Reporting and explaining the usefulness of volunteers to your organization	43.7	27.7	2.886 (p < 0.004)	39.5

Notes. Table reports percentages. Bold indicates statistically significant difference. Italics indicates elements for shared guidance models.

volunteer practitioners consider the element as “Very Important.” Moreover, for 11 of the 16 elements, the differences in percentages between the paid and unpaid administrators achieve statistical significance (another difference in percentages nearly attains statistical significance $p < 0.083$). As we had anticipated, to the degree that the elements tap a new tool kit or technology for volunteer administration, the more professional volunteer administrators have come to embrace it more fully as “Very Important.”

7 | DISCUSSION

Although the Volunteer Stewardship Framework may provide new insights into volunteer management, our study has limitations that should be noted. The research is cross-sectional, and as we have acknowledged we created several items that had not received prior testing or evaluation. Because our survey was administered online, we restricted the length to two pages to stimulate response. This exercise brought a helpful discipline to our inquiry, but it also lessened our ability to include additional items to refine and evaluate operationalization: The measurement of key practices in volunteer administration and management would benefit from further development and testing. We were not able to administer our online survey to a random sample; as we discussed earlier, however, through the assistance of the Netherlands Organization on Volunteering we believe we contacted appropriate respondents and succeeded in obtaining a heterogeneous response.

Our inquiry has other limitations. We were able to seek empirical validation for the Volunteer Stewardship Framework in the Netherlands, which likely affected the composition of our sample. Given the specific context and small size of the Netherlands (relatively few volunteer centers, universities, etc.), the sample does not include many volunteer administrators working in the secondary and intermediary models. Although larger samples would be desirable and await further research, these respondents still account for one-fifth of our sample. By contrast, because the membership model is relatively prominent in the Netherlands, a large group of these administrators responded. Volunteer administrators in the service-delivery model are also well-represented in the sample, just as this model of volunteer administration occurs frequently in western democracies. Nevertheless, the prevalence of the different models likely varies cross-nationally, and we would welcome replication to examine this expectation and its implications empirically.

Our cross-sectional research leaves open the question of how the passage of time might affect the Volunteer Stewardship Framework. Based on emerging trends we might anticipate three developments. First, the past two decades evince a movement toward short-term and episodic volunteer assignments (Hustinx, Handy, & Cnaan, 2010). With respect to the guidance dimension, such limited volunteer engagements render standard HRM elements both more costly and more inconvenient for organizations, so that we might expect use of these practices to decline over time (e.g., regular supervision and communication with volunteers, liability coverage or insurance protection, etc.), although they remain prominent at present. Second, the increase in the use of the internet to recruit and mobilize prospective volunteers (Cravens & Ellis, 2014) may affect the access dimension to make volunteer energy more generally available across organizations: The internet may weaken “private” access to volunteers, so that more organizations will find themselves competing for their services in the “common pool” of volunteers. As a result, the recruitment practices in the Volunteer Stewardship Framework may rise in importance. Third, cultural changes such as individualization and secularization may affect the ways volunteers can be accessed (Hustinx & Lammertyn, 2003; Von Essen, Hustinx, Haers, & Mels, 2015).

These limitations should be considered in evaluating our main conclusions. First, as described by Studer and von Schnurbein (2013) and leading texts (Seel, 2016; Connors, 2011), a basic set of HRM practices garner high attributions of “Very Important” from volunteer administration practitioners across all four models in our Volunteer Stewardship Framework: membership, service-delivery, secondary, and intermediary. Aside from measurement aspects which are not highly regarded in any of the models, well over one-third of the sample, and usually more (around half or more), view these elements as “Very Important.” What emerges as new from our analysis is that beyond universal obeisance to the standard HRM elements, in the shared guidance models, that is, secondary and intermediary, additional elements command the attention of volunteer administration practitioners relating to the need to promote the volunteer program externally and to work with partner organizations. On four of the five relevant items the analyses of variance presented in Table 3 yield the statistically significant differences anticipated by this cross-organizational context.

To our knowledge, the literature has not attended to the management demands of the shared volunteer guidance models. An important element of these models is the necessity of cooperation between volunteer managers across organizations, yet our present inquiry cannot shed light on how this cooperation is practiced. We recommend further that research incorporate all parties to the relationship.

Second, the data analysis may show some migration of the field of volunteer administration toward a more “regenerative” approach (Brudney & Meijs, 2009). Because the elements that we had proposed meant to inject a more volunteer-centric perspective into the analysis have not been offered

and tested previously, however, we must be skeptical of drawing firm conclusions. For example, one of the items that we had intended to center on the accomplishments and rewards of individual volunteers (“evaluating and rewarding volunteers”) seems similar to the organization-level “recognition activities, such as award ceremonies for volunteers” incorporated in the inventory of recommended HRM practices of Hager and Brudney (2004). Operationalizing and analyzing a more volunteer-centric perspective for volunteer administration will require further research.

Third, we began by proposing a Volunteer Stewardship Framework to consolidate and simplify the plethora of models of volunteer administration found in the literature. The framework intersects two key dimensions: whether guidance of volunteers is unitary versus shared, and whether access to volunteer energy is private versus common. While the first of these dimensions yielded large, statistically significant, and substantively important percentage differences in attributions of “Very Important” on relevant task elements of volunteer administration, the second dimension was less successful. Whether a volunteer program is able to draw its volunteers from a relatively “private” resource, such as members (membership model) or employees or students (secondary model), versus from a “common pool,” as in a service-delivery organization (service model) or a volunteer center or like organization (intermediary model), seems to matter less with respect to the tasks of volunteer administration. Nevertheless, the requisites of volunteer administration in membership organizations appear to be distinctive: The volunteer administration practitioners working in this model generally give the lowest attributions of “Very Important” across all task elements. This finding, and the potential significance of access to volunteer energy as a dimension for comprehending volunteer administration, likewise call for further research.

8 | CONCLUSION

This research proposed and evaluated empirically a new Volunteer Stewardship Framework for understanding when, why, and how the requisites of volunteer administration and management may be changing. As opposed to existing conditional models of volunteer administration, our goal was to provide a more straightforward, yet essential, basis for the classification and management of volunteer programs. The premise underlying the Volunteer Stewardship Framework is that volunteer managers and their organizations face two essential tasks: First, all volunteer programs and the communities they belong to must be concerned with having access to enough volunteer energy to sustain themselves, and second, all volunteer programs and communities must be concerned with giving volunteers the proper support and guidance to provide a quality experience to safeguard retention and “volunteer energy” (Brudney & Meijs, 2009, 2013).

Crossing the two dimensions of the Volunteer Stewardship Framework of access to volunteer energy and guidance of volunteers yields four models of volunteer administration and management. In the “membership” model the organization enjoys private access to volunteers, who contribute their time toward its goals and purposes (unitary guidance); the home organization (where volunteer energy originates) and the host organization (where the volunteers assist) are the same. In the “service” model the organization accesses volunteers from the common pool outside of it in the larger community, and this entity enjoys unitary guidance of their work and performance, as in a social service nonprofit or government agency that enlists volunteers. In the “secondary” model the home organization again enjoys private access to volunteers, but the volunteers are deployed to host organizations outside of it, so that home and host share guidance of the volunteers, as in a school-based community service program or an employee (or corporate) volunteer program. Finally, in the “intermediary” model volunteers are accessed from across the community

(common access), and the home organization works with various host organizations to place them externally, with volunteer guidance again shared, as in the relationship between a volunteer center and its partnering organizations.

An insight offered by the Volunteer Stewardship Framework is that in the shared volunteer programs we might expect to see reliance on the traditional HRM approach to volunteer management supplemented with an emphasis on reaching out externally to increase collaboration between home and host organizations (and home and host volunteer managers) and volunteering in the community. By contrast to the unitary volunteer-involving organizations (membership and service-delivery), where the “home” and “host” organization of the volunteer are more or less the same, in the shared volunteer-involving organizations (secondary and intermediary) the home (sending) and host (receiving) organizations are separate. As a consequence, in the latter volunteers will have to deal with two volunteer managers, and these managers will need to communicate. Lacking this communication would be detrimental for creating value not only for home and host organizations but also for volunteers and clients. Statistical analysis based on this expectation yielded the strongest support.

Such findings carry larger implications for the study and practice of volunteer administration. Professional conferences and journals tend to treat the demands and recommended “best practices” of membership management in associations, service-delivery organizations and their volunteers, corporate social responsibility employee-based volunteer programs as well as community service-learning arrangements in educational institutions, and the workings of intermediary organizations such as volunteer centers, as separate and distinct topics. Students and practitioners can find literature, and/or participate in respective academic or practitioner conferences in each of these domains, yet miss consideration of how volunteer administrators address the same problems, challenges, and opportunities they encounter in related, if overlooked, areas of volunteer administration and management. Absent cross-fertilization of study and practice from one model of volunteer administration and management to the next, relevant knowledge may not be apprehended or applied, and research effort and funding fail to achieve their greatest benefit and return. A primary lesson of our analysis is that all four models elaborated in this inquiry center on volunteer management, and that they can be understood to incorporate to varying degrees a set of managerial tasks or elements for this purpose. In our view examining these organizational arrangements together rather than individually as proposed in our Volunteer Stewardship Framework has much to offer the field of volunteer administration.

ENDNOTES

¹In classifying the organizations in which respondents worked according to the Volunteer Stewardship Framework, 62 respondents were filtered out, as they answered the organizational background questions in ways inconsistent with other answers, or because they self-identified with an organization that does not unambiguously fit the Framework.

²In translating the Hager and Brudney (2004) items to Dutch and preparing the online survey, we regrettably omitted one of their items: “Training and professional development opportunities for volunteers.”

³Dutch databases vary in number of nonprofit organizations. The Dutch Central Bureau of Statistics (Arends & Smeets, 2018) claims a total of 38,245 foundations and associations. The National Olympic Committee (2018) claims at least 23,870 local sport associations connected to official sports federations. News outlets show varying counts of nonprofit organizations ranging from 43,000 to 250,000. These discrepancies could stem from differences in official legal forms or relationships to national organizations.

⁴Because we sought to test the differences in items with respect to “Very Important” versus all other categories, we created dummy variables for each item (1 = very important, 0 = somewhat important or not important). We employed a one-way analysis of variance in Table 3 and an independent samples *t* test in Table 4.

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